



Figure 3: Auto completion in Vim



Figure 4: Using multiple files side-by-side

the first word of every line

- `:%s/word_pattern/replacement_text/` - global replacement of the word
- `:%s/word_pattern/replacement_text/gc` - replacement with interactive *Yes/No* confirmation

`%s` represents the entire text in the file. It is also possible to use a range of lines for replacement. In case we want to use a replacement only between the lines 1 and 25, the above command can be used as:

```
1:25 s/word_pattern/replacement_text/
```

You can also use regular expressions for replacement and searching. This is similar to the *sed* (stream editor) syntax.

## Repeating commands *N* times

If you want to repeat a specific command *N* number of times, prefix the number of times before the command. For example, to copy the next five lines, use `5yy`, where `yy` is the command for copying 1 line. To move the cursor to the eighth word of a line, use `8w`.

## Selecting text

Vim has an awesome option to select a portion of text, just as we do using a mouse in GUI-based editors. The special purpose option is called Visual Mode.

Press `'v` in the command mode and navigate the cursor—the selected text will be highlighted. After making the necessary selection, press a command for an operation.

For example, press `'v`, and make selections by moving the cursor down and right. For deletion, press `'d`, or any other required operation.

## Advanced Vim features

Vim is an advanced editor that has capabilities like spell check, auto indentation for different programming languages, auto-completion, syntax colouring and more. Syntax colouring and auto indentation enables programmers to write code in an artistic way, making the code more pleasing to the eye. Vim also supports colouring schemes with themes.

## Syntax colours and auto indent

To enable syntax colouring, use the command line : *syntax on*.

Vim supports many programming languages for indentation. To enable indentation, use the command line, *:set autoindent*. To explicitly enable C syntax indentation, use *:set cindent*.

## Spell check and auto complete

Vim also supports spell checking. It highlights wrongly spelled words with a different colour. To enable spell checking, at the command line, use *:setlocal spell spelllang=en\_us*, for US English while writing a document.

For auto completion of a word or a keyword, type a part of the word and press `Ctrl+N`, after which a pop-up will show the list of available words (Figure 3). You can scroll through the word list by pressing `Ctrl+N` repeatedly. Auto completion works for words that have already been typed previously in the current file.

Install the *ctags* package if you want inbuilt auto-completion support for various programming languages as well.

## Split windows

There are certain occasions when you need to work with multiple files simultaneously. Normally when you want to refer to the contents of a file while working on another file, you open two instances of editors side-by-side. But Vim is intelligent enough to open multiple files simultaneously.

To start a horizontal window by splitting the current Vim instance, use the command `Ctrl+w+s`, or at the command line, use *:split*. For a vertical split, type `Ctrl+w+h`, or at the command line, *:vsplit*. Refer to Figure 4. You can now switch between different split instances using the `Ctrl+w+w` shortcut. These multiple splits can be further split using the same commands. The split windows act as separate instances of Vim so that we can